Production order: from here to public release, with playable betas along the way

Context

The world, the nine dungeon interiors, the battle engine, crafting and 100 of 101 enemy sprites exist. What is missing is everything that lets a stranger play: there is no title, save, death consequence, packaging, NPCs, dialogue, shops, boss placement, audio or ending. Bosses are reachable only through the F3 debug list.

So the order below is driven by one rule: **each stage ends in a build other people can download and play**, and content is finished in the order players meet it (by difficulty tier outward from the start), not by enemy id.

This is an order of work only. Nothing here is implemented yet.

Where things stand (working tree, 2026-10-10)

Area	State
Patterns	65 of 101 bespoke. 36 left: 65, 89, all 15 SEVERE, 11 of 14 ELITE, all 8 bosses
Bullets from the sprite part	31 measured; 24 finished patterns (mostly 00-17, 50-59) still fire from the centre
Enemy art	3 mismatched eras; 84-99, 51, 52 are roughs; 65 has no sprite
Bosses	Tiers exist (BOSS1 06/23/30, BOSS2 34/44/49/52, BOSS3 100). No placement, no defeated flags, no gate
Phases	Two per enemy only. Flesh Planet needs more
Settlements	Town 0 done. Towns 1-2, 12 villages, 3 castles are coloured placeholder blocks
Outer game	No title, save, respawn, options, NPCs, dialogue, shops, quests, audio, ending, packaging

Two standing rules

1. A "ready" gate. One list of enemy ids that are finished (art adjusted, bullets from the part, pattern play-tested). The dungeon picker (`dungeon_pick_enemy`, `src/dungeon.cpp:2582`) only picks ready enemies, falling back to the nearest ready tier. The same list feeds the DONE tags in `tools/enemy_tier_sheet.py`, which today are typed by hand each run. This is what makes every beta safe to ship: testers never meet a stub. Likewise, settlements with an empty blueprint are not stamped at all, so no magenta or checker blocks appear.

2. The per-enemy loop, art first. For each enemy, in this order:

1. Adjust the sprite (Aseprite) to the final style.
2. Measure the part the bullets leave from, per facing.
3. Write or revise the pattern; give each phase its stage name.
4. `battlecensus` for fairness, then you play-test it.

5. Add the id to the ready list and commit.

This changes one earlier decision, and it is yours to overrule: the note in memory says one style pass over all sprites at the very end. I recommend doing the style pass **per tier band, just before that band ships**, because the bullet anchors move when a sprite is redrawn (so measuring before the redraw is done twice) and because testers will see the art from the first beta.

The stages

Stage 0: a build a stranger can run (starting island only)

Content is what exists: the house, town 0, the raft opening, the two starter dungeons, enemies 00-02.

- Commit the current working tree first; it is large and uncommitted.
- Package: a script that produces a zip with `game.exe`, the SDL DLLs and `assets/`, runnable from any folder. Test it on a PC without MSYS2.
- Title screen with new game / continue (`STATE_TITLE` is an empty case, `src/main.cpp:823`).
- Save and load: world seed, player, inventory, `items_found`, a flags block for bosses and quests, and a save version. Say on the title screen that beta saves may be wiped.
- Death: wake at home (or the last sleeping bag) with HP restored. Today a defeat leaves the player at 0 HP.
- Debug keys (F1/F2/F3, B, R/T in battle, minimap teleport) behind a build flag; remove the test enemy from the spawn house.
- Dungeon chasers drawn with the enemy's sprite instead of red squares (`src/main.cpp:1330`).
- Version number on the title screen, a changelog file, and one place for testers to report (itch.io page comments or a form).
- Run enemies 00-02 through the per-enemy loop.

Ship: Beta 0.1 to a handful of friends. The question for them: does it start, save, and survive dying?

Stage 1: the mainland and the first boss

- Audio plumbing (SDL_mixer, music and effect volume in an options screen), then sound effects for shots, hits, grazes, pickups and menus. Effects come this early because they change how patterns read.
- Dialogue: a multi-line textbox with a speaker, lower-case letters in the font, and NPCs who stand in town 0 and its interiors.
- Shop: the book shop sells the axe, katana and scythe books for gold (`src/crafting.cpp:53` already promises this). Persist collected gold piles at the same time, or re-entering a dungeon is free money.
- Stage name cards before each battle stage (three names already chosen).
- Boss plumbing, built once for all eight: a placed overworld lair, a defeated flag in the save, a trigger that starts the fight.
- Boss 06: art, pattern, lair, and the first quest lead from town 0.
- LOW and MEDIUM bands (30 enemies) through the per-enemy loop. Most of the 24 centre-firing patterns are here. Enemy 65 gets its sprite and pattern.

Ship: Beta 0.2. Question: can a new player find and beat a boss from town talk alone?

Stage 2: the public demo (three bosses)

- UPPER and HARD bands (33 enemies) through the loop, plus 89's pattern.
- Bosses 23 and 30 with lairs and quest leads. Rebalance legacy HP (06 has 45).
- One village blueprint, reused for all 12 for now (`tools/tile_editor.cpp`), with an NPC or two each for the leads.
- First music: title, overworld, town, dungeon, battle, boss.
- A "demo ends here" card after the third boss; tiers above HARD stay behind the ready gate.
- Key rebinding and a proper pause screen with quit.

Ship: the demo, publicly (itch.io, and a Steam demo if you want Steam for release). From here on, each later stage is an update to people who already have the game.

Stage 3: the farlands (four bosses)

- Decide first what the castles are. Recommendation: the four castles hold the four BOSS2 fights. Three sites are already placed (ocean, mountain, lava), the fourth is "found only by dungeon diving", and the working title is Four Castle Chronicles. This needs castle blueprints, an interior or arena each, and the item that crosses the lava moat (`src/tilemap.cpp:1786`).
- Redraw the roughs (84-99, 51, 52), then SEVERE and ELITE bands (26 patterns) through the loop.
- Bosses 34, 44, 49, 52: patterns, lairs, four quest leads. Reset 49's test HP of 1,000,000.
- Towns 1 and 2 authored; the other three village variants.
- Music for the farlands and the BOSS2 fights.

Ship: Beta 0.5. Question: is the climb from boss 3 to boss 7 fair, and is the arsenal growing fast enough to match?

Stage 4: the ending

- Gate: all seven flags set opens the way home.
- The walk home with the world dissolving.
- Flesh Planet: needs more than two phases, so extend the phase rule (`ENRAGED`, `src/enemies.cpp:109`) to a list of thresholds rather than adding a special case for one boss.
- The true world, both worlds reachable afterwards, credits.

Ship: to a few closed testers only, so the ending is not spoiled before release.

Stage 5: release

- Balance pass across the whole curve using `spawncensus` and tester reports: EXP, ore bands, gold prices.
- Zoom limited to the three shipped tiers (0.75x / 1x / 1.5x).
- Remaining music, final sound pass.
- Fresh-save playthrough start to credits on the packaged build. Then 1.0.

How long it will take

These are estimates in **working days** (a full day of you plus Claude sessions), not promises. They rest on the pace in the git history and working tree: about 100 rough sprites in six days (2-7 Oct) and roughly 55 patterns in the three days after. That pace is fast, so the limit is your play-testing and art approval, not the writing of code.

Stage	Main costs	Working days	If worked most days, done about
0. Runnable build	save and title 2, packaging, death, debug flag, chasers, 3 enemies	4-6	mid-late Oct 2026
1. Mainland, first boss	30 enemies at ~6 a day 5, dialogue and NPCs 3, effects 3, boss plumbing 2, boss 06 2, shop 1.5, audio and options 1, name cards 1	18-22	mid-late Nov 2026
2. Public demo	33 enemies 6, two bosses 4, six music tracks 6-12, village and NPCs 3, pause and rebinding 2, store page and trailer 3	24-32	early-mid Jan 2027
3. Farlands	four castles 6-8, four bosses 8, 26 patterns 6-7, towns 1-2 6, redraw 18 roughs 4-5, villages 3, music 4	36-42	March 2027
4. Ending	Flesh Planet 6-8, the dissolving walk 4-5, the true world 5-10, gate and credits 1.5	16-25	April 2027
5. Release	balance 5, remaining music 5, full playthroughs and fixes 5-10	15-20	May-June 2027
Total		**about 115-145**	

So: a first build for friends in about a week, the public demo in about ten weeks of work, and release after roughly five to seven months of work.

What moves these numbers most:

- **Your calendar.** The history shows bursts (7-22 Aug, 27 Sep to now) with gaps of weeks between. At that rhythm the calendar time roughly doubles: demo around March 2027, release late 2027.
- **Music.** I assumed one to two days a track and that you make or commission it. It is the least known cost here.
- **The true world.** Its size is not designed yet; 5-10 days assumes it reuses the existing world with changed art, not a second world.
- **Tester feedback.** Each beta should sit with players for a week or so before the next stage's balance is trusted. That wait overlaps with the next stage's work, so it is not added above.
- **Redoing art.** If a tier band's sprites need more than an adjustment, the 6-a-day rate for that band drops to 2-3.

Running it across sessions

You run several Claude sessions at once, and every pattern session edits the same 7,600-line `src/enemies.cpp`. Three lanes that rarely touch the same files:

- **Enemy lane:** the per-enemy loop, one enemy per session, commit when it joins the ready list.
- **Systems lane:** one outer-game item at a time (save, dialogue, shop, boss plumbing, audio).
- **World lane:** blueprints, lairs, castle and village art.

How to tell a stage is done

- The packaged zip runs on a machine without MSYS2, from a new save, to the end of that stage's content with debug keys off.
- Every enemy added to the ready list has a clean `battlecensus` run and your play-test.
- `spawncensus` shows no ready enemy as never picked; `craftcheck` and `dngportals` exit clean.
- The tier sheet (`tools/enemy_tier_sheet.py`) shows the stage's bands fully tagged DONE.

Not in this plan

Overworld encounters (battles happen only in dungeons today) and optional side quests. Add either after the demo if testers say the overworld feels empty.